

## OBJECTIVES

- Evaluate the effectiveness of current sanctions
- Assess unintended consequences
- Recalibrate a coordinated international response

BACKGROUND GUIDE

# Presidential Council

## Recalibrating Russia's Sanctions

LANGUAGE

ENGLISH

FORMAT

PAIRS

DEPUTY UNDER-SECRETARIAT-GENERAL

UNITED NATIONS



# MONUA XVI

## UNIVERSIDAD DE LOS ANDES MODEL UNITED NATIONS

The Universidad de los Andes Model United Nations (MONUA) is an academic conference organized by students of Universidad de los Andes with the support of the Faculty of Social Sciences. Throughout more than fifteen editions, MONUA has established itself as a distinguished forum where secondary school and university students from Colombia and around the world come together to engage in diplomacy, debate, and the collaborative development of solutions to contemporary global challenges.

Through the representation of Member States, international organizations, institutions, and other relevant actors, participants research, negotiate, deliberate, and collaborate on political, social, economic, legal, and humanitarian issues. Beyond competition, MONUA is an educational experience designed to strengthen critical thinking, public speaking, leadership, empathy, and respect for diverse perspectives.

Inclusion and social responsibility remain fundamental pillars of the conference. Through initiatives such as Learning with MONUA, MONUA Fellowship, and other educational programs, MONUA seeks to make diplomacy, negotiation, and leadership opportunities accessible to children and young people from a wide variety of backgrounds.

Under the theme #EmpoweringEveryVoice, MONUA XVI reaffirms its commitment to creating spaces where every participant can contribute, learn, and advocate for their ideas through academic excellence, mutual respect, and international cooperation.

This edition will feature educational committees, United Nations bodies, specialized and legal committees, crisis cabinets, as well as media and interconnectivity committees. These Background Guides are intended to serve as the starting point for delegates' research, while the MONUA XVI Handbook outlines the conference's Rules of Procedure, code of conduct, and general policies.

MONUA XVI invites every participant to exchange ideas, embrace new perspectives, overcome challenges, and develop solutions that extend beyond the committee room. Each Background Guide has been carefully prepared to support delegates throughout their research process and to provide the foundation for informed, rigorous, and responsible participation.

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# Welcome Letters

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Board of Directors · Senior Staff · Committee Dais

Opening messages from the members of the Board of Directors, Senior Staff, and Committee Dais, whose leadership, commitment, and dedication make MONUA XVI possible.





## Secretary-General

**Salome Rodríguez Ballesteros**

s.rodriquezb2345@uniandes.edu.co

Dear Participants of MONUA XVI,

If you are reading this letter, it means you are about to embark on an experience that I am certain will leave a lasting impact on you in many ways. Beyond debates, position papers, and resolutions, MONUA is a place to learn from others, discover new perspectives, and appreciate the value of diplomacy, dialogue, and cooperation.

My name is Salome Rodríguez Ballesteros, and it is my great honor to welcome you this year as the Secretary-General of MONUA XVI. I am currently pursuing a degree in Global Studies and Political Science, with concentrations in International Law and Economics. Like many of you, I found in Model United Nations a place where I learned that words, when used with respect and purpose, have the power to transform realities. I remember exactly what it feels like to arrive at your first conference with a mixture of excitement, uncertainty, and high expectations. I also remember the thrill of delivering my first speech, meeting extraordinary people, and realizing that these experiences are not about always being right, but about being willing to listen, learn, and grow. That is the experience I hope each of you will have at MONUA XVI.

Whether this is your very first conference or you have participated in many before, every committee is a new opportunity to challenge yourself, step outside your comfort zone, and discover abilities you may not yet know you possess. Do not hesitate to raise your placard, defend your ideas with respect, and build bridges even when differences arise. After all, that is what the United Nations stands for, and it is the spirit we strive to cultivate at MONUA. I want you to know that this edition has been prepared with great care by a team that truly believes in the transformative impact of these experiences. My greatest hope is that, when MONUA XVI comes to an end, you will leave with far more than an award or a certificate. I hope you leave with lasting friendships, meaningful lessons, and the confidence to continue using your voice wherever life takes you.

Thank you for placing your trust in us and for being part of this edition. I hope you enjoy every debate, every conversation, and every moment throughout the conference. I am confident that this experience will be only the beginning of many great things to come.

With my warmest regards,

Salome Rodríguez Ballesteros

Secretary-General

MONUA XVI – Universidad de Los Andes



## Academic Secretary

**Juliana Solano Sossa**

[j.solanos2@uniandes.edu.co](mailto:j.solanos2@uniandes.edu.co)

Dear delegates, sponsors, staff members, and all those whom it may concern,

My name is Juliana Solano, and I have the honor of serving as the Academic Secretary of MONUA XVI. I am currently in my eighth semester of Law and am pursuing a double degree in Business Administration at Universidad de los Andes. Throughout my journey in Model United Nations, I have found in these spaces not only a setting for rigorous academic training, but also a project that has allowed me to grow, challenge myself, and build a community of which I have felt deeply proud since the very first moment I became a part of it.

Today, I would like to warmly welcome you to this conference. We are truly delighted that you have decided to take on this challenge and become part of this edition. MONUA is not only a place to learn theory, debate, or refine argumentative skills—which are undoubtedly fundamental—but also a space to build experiences, create genuine connections, and discover the potential that each and every one of you possesses. My invitation is for you to approach this process not only with discipline, but also with intention and dedication. Allow yourselves to go beyond what is expected, to question, propose, and build. Take advantage of every debate, every intervention, and every interaction as an opportunity for growth. I hope this conference will be a space that challenges you academically, while also leaving a mark on you personally. May you find here not only a stage on which to excel, but also a place to share, make friends, and enjoy the process.

Welcome to MONUA XVI.

With my full commitment to accompany you throughout this process,

Juliana Solano Sossa  
Academic Secretary  
MONUA XVI



## Director-General

**Samir David Fernández Yunis**

s.fernandezy@uniandes.edu.co

Dear Participants, welcome to the sixteenth edition of MONUA.

My name is Samir David Fernández Yunis, and it is my pleasure to serve as the Director-General of MONUA XVI. I am currently in my seventh semester of Electronic Engineering at Universidad de los Andes, and for several years, Model United Nations has been a fundamental part of my academic and personal journey. From my first conferences in high school to my experience in the university MUN circuit, these experiences have challenged me, helped me grow, and allowed me to understand the world through a wide range of perspectives.

Throughout this journey, I have come to understand that MUN is a space where ideas, interests, and worldviews that often seem irreconcilable come together. It is precisely within that diversity that the most meaningful experiences emerge. To disagree is not to confront one another, but rather to engage with ideas, institutions, and perspectives that deserve to be questioned with rigor, integrity, and respect. That is the spirit we strive to foster at MONUA. For this edition, we set ourselves a clear objective: to deliver a conference that meets the standards of the most competitive delegations in Colombia and the region while preserving the international character that defines MONUA. The participation of delegations from across Latin America not only elevates the quality of debate but also transforms this conference into a true academic and cultural meeting point.

Our goal is to offer a conference that is ambitious, thoughtfully designed, and carefully executed in every academic and logistical aspect. Beyond committees and debates, MONUA is an experience. I hope these four days become not only an intellectual challenge, but also an opportunity to meet remarkable people, build lasting connections, and discover your own potential. I would like to express my sincere gratitude to everyone who has made this project possible: our academic team, the Board of Directors, our staff, and each one of you for placing your trust in this process. MONUA exists because of this collective commitment, and I am confident that this edition will meet your expectations and leave you with far more than outstanding results—it will leave you with unforgettable experiences and lasting connections.

With respect and sincere regards,

Samir David Fernández Yunis  
Director-General  
MONUA XVI

## WELCOME LETTERS

## BOARD OF DIRECTORS



## Deputy Academic Secretary

**Jose Alejandro Gutiérrez Cifuentes**

ja.gutierrezc1@uniandes.edu.co

Dear Sponsors, Delegates, Observers, Staff Members, Parents, and Anyone Else Who Decided to Read This Letter,

Welcome to MONUA! A place to debate, to think, and—most importantly—to question.

My name is Jose Alejandro Gutiérrez Cifuentes, and for the sixteenth edition of MONUA, I am delighted to serve as the Deputy Academic Secretary of the conference.

I am currently pursuing a master's degree in Physics at Universidad de los Andes, and ever since I was young, I have loved movies, philosophy, and wonderfully terrible jokes. Somehow, all of those interests found a home in crisis committees, where I developed not only those passions but also the skills that have shaped the person I am today. Through MUN, I have learned to approach problems from multiple perspectives and to appreciate the value of interdisciplinary thinking.

Despite the many people who have tried to convince me that my academic background has little to do with Model United Nations, I have come to believe quite the opposite. When our goal is to pursue truth and strive to do things well, we cannot rely solely on the exact sciences. We also need the tools that dialogue, diplomacy, and debate provide. I hope this conference becomes, for you, what it has been for me: an opportunity to grow and, in our own small way, make the world a little better. I also hope that throughout this experience you find a space to collaborate with honesty, creativity, and an open mind, making the most of everything MONUA has to offer.

If this message resonates with even one person by the end of MONUA XVI, I will gladly quote two of my country's greatest icons with complete confidence: «There is something about Colombians: we never lose hope of doing better every single time,» and «We've lowered the ignorance levels just a tiny bit, professor,» by Jaime Garzón and La Cevichica, respectively.

Thank you, best of luck, and I'll see you at MONUA.

With warm regards,

Jose Alejandro Gutiérrez Cifuentes

Deputy Academic Secretary

MONUA XVI





## Deputy Director-General

**María José Penagos**

[mj.penagos@uniandes.edu.co](mailto:mj.penagos@uniandes.edu.co)

Dear delegates, sponsors, staff members, and everyone who is part of this story today: welcome to the sixteenth edition of MONUA!

My name is María José Penagos Granados, and I have the immense privilege of serving as the Deputy Secretary-General of MONUA XVI. I am currently pursuing a double major in Government and Public Affairs and Business Administration at Universidad de los Andes.

Ever since I was very young, Model United Nations has held a special place in my life. It taught me that ideas have the power to transform realities, that listening is just as important as speaking, and that true leadership is, above all, about creating opportunities for others to shine.

To me, MONUA is so much more than a conference. It is a place that inspires, challenges, and transforms. It is where people from different backgrounds and perspectives come together and discover that dialogue will always be more powerful than division, and that the most meaningful solutions emerge when we choose to build them together. I truly believe that change begins with those who dare to participate, to question, and to believe they can make a difference.

Thank you for placing your trust in this project and for choosing to be part of this edition. Behind every detail is a team that has worked with dedication, enthusiasm, and genuine care to create an unforgettable experience for all of you. I hope you will feel that commitment in every committee, every debate, and every moment you share throughout these days.

I encourage you to embrace MONUA with enthusiasm and generosity. Make the most of every speech, every hallway conversation, and every person you have the chance to meet. Allow yourselves to learn, to make mistakes, to grow, and to be surprised. Don't be afraid to raise your placard, stand up for your ideas, or listen openly to perspectives that challenge your own.

When MONUA XVI comes to an end, I hope you leave with far more than wonderful memories. I hope you take home lasting friendships, lessons that will stay with you for years to come, and the certainty that each of you has the power to create a positive impact. This conference is now yours—embrace it with curiosity, conviction, and an open heart.

With warmth, respect, and admiration,

María José Penagos Granados

Deputy Director-General MONUA XVI

## WELCOME LETTERS

## Deputy Under-Secretary-General



USG

UNITED NATIONS

### Raúl Ruiz Aragón

[rs.ruiza1@uniandes.edu.co](mailto:rs.ruiza1@uniandes.edu.co)

Hello everyone,

My name is Raúl Ruiz, a sixth-semester student of Systems Engineering and Government and Public Affairs at Universidad de los Andes, and together with Sebastián Delgado I will be your Assistant Secretary-General for the United Nations at MONUA this year. I hope we meet your expectations and that you enjoy the best Model United Nations in Colombia.

I have been involved in the world of Model United Nations for several years. Since high school, it has greatly interested me, and in university I have had the opportunity to be part of a delegation from my university and attend both national and international conferences. Therefore, I value academic rigor, debates with strong arguments, and not just a delegate who speaks loudly and uses the placard. However, this does not mean that debates have to be boring—I really enjoy when the committee is engaging and the debates are held to a high standard.

Setting aside the UN world, I really enjoy football (Real Madrid), Formula 1, and politics. So, having a coffee and talking about any of these topics can be the best plan I can think of.

I hope we have very interesting debates and that you enjoy MONUA. Beyond an award—which ends up in a drawer—be good people, meet others, and enjoy this experience which, at its core, is a simulation.

Sincerely,  
Raúl Ruiz Aragón  
United Nations USG  
MONUA XVI

## WELCOME LETTERS

## Deputy Under-Secretary-General

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USG

UNITED NATIONS

### Sebastián Delgado Cabrera

[sdelgadoca@unal.edu.co](mailto:sdelgadoca@unal.edu.co)

Greetings to everyone,

My name is Sebastián Delgado, and together with Raúl I have the honor of serving as the Assistant Secretary-General for the United Nations for this edition of the Model United Nations of Universidad de los Andes, MONUA XVI. I am a Mechanical Engineering student at the Universidad Nacional de Colombia, and although my field of study may seem notably distant from Model UN spaces, my interest in these events began in high school, where I came to believe that, regardless of one's career, communication and debate skills are indispensable for being a critical and constructive citizen in a country where dialogue is often one of the last resorts. For this reason, I am a strong advocate of traditional committees, where these characteristics are most fully developed.

Together with Raúl, we have designed a robust proposal characterized by academic rigor, where we aim for delegates to fully develop their capabilities in soft skills, research, and conflict resolution, while maintaining the procedural character that defines our ASG team. We hope that those who are part of it share the same passion we have for these spaces and stand out as well-rounded delegates, with a constant balance between substantive knowledge and discourse management, capable of building consensus, with a genuine intention to learn and a strong commitment to building a competitive and human committee.

From the SGA team, we are fully available to every individual who is part of the model to share a space that helps us grow as people, develop academically, and leave a mark on a circuit that, within its competitive mindset, has at times forgotten its main objective: to learn and to build connections with people from all corners of our country, and in this case, from across Latin America as a whole.

Sincerely,

Sebastián Delgado Cabrera

United Nations USG

MONUA XVI

## WELCOME LETTERS

# Presidential Council



Chair

**Elisa Brenes**

elisabrenes04@gmail.com

Hi Delegates!!

My name is Elisa Brenes and alongside Danna and Sara, I will be your Dais for MONUA XVI edition of the Presidential Council. I'm currently in seventh semester of civil engineering at the Universidad de los Andes, however I did start as a physics major (don't ask me why, I don't know either). I was born and raised in Managua, Nicaragua for 13 years before moving to Cali, Colombia. Ever since 2017, I have had the pleasure to call Cali and Bogotá my homes and I wouldn't have it any other way. As a kid in high school, I thoroughly enjoyed MUN, hence why it extended into my university years. Just as a couple more fun facts about myself: I'm the eldest of three, my parents and siblings currently live in CDMX, and I have a deep love for sitcoms (mainly Friends, The Office, and Modern Family).

Though many may see MUN as a roleplaying game, the reality is that within the walls of the committee every delegate is enforcing critical thinking and applying foreign policy in order to reach solutions to conflicts ranging back decades. Surrounding ourselves with these sorts of environments help us reach beyond the stars and truly comprehend the inner gears of our political climate.

I have high expectations of this committee and of our delegates, deeply encouraging thinking outside the box and reaching resolutions that haven't previously been planted. Whilst not encouraging you to go far beyond your nation's current policy, I do remind you all that this is the Presidential Council; what you say gets done. The sky is the limit for you guys, and I can't wait to see what you come up with.

In case you have any doubts regarding the topic or any other aspects of the committee, don't hesitate to reach out!! Best of luck, and see you in MONUA XVI.

Elisa Brenes  
Chair of the Presidential Council

## WELCOME LETTERS

# Presidential Council



Chair

## Danna Calvo

d.calvo@uniandes.edu.co  
Cel. +57 312 332 2712

Hey everyone!

My name is Danna Calvo, I'm 19 years old, I'm currently in my sixth semester of law at the Universidad de Los Andes, and I'm very excited to be your dais for the Presidential Council in this edition of MONUA XVI.

This council is tasked with examining a policy framework that stands at the intersection of geopolitics, economics, and international responsibility. The topics before you—liquefied natural gas (LNG) restrictions, banking penalties, and worldwide tariff structures—are not isolated measures but interconnected instruments that shape global energy security, financial stability, and international trade. Your deliberations will determine how these tools can be recalibrated to remain effective, proportional, and aligned with evolving global realities.

A careful balance between economic pressure, international legality, and global repercussions is imperative. The objective of this council is not merely to adjust sanctions but to ensure that they are strategically targeted, ethically grounded, and capable of responding to both political objectives and humanitarian concerns. As global markets and diplomatic dynamics evolve at an accelerated pace, policy responses must evolve with equal rigor and responsibility.

I expect delegates to debate with character and confidence, for them to be able to have clear ideas and a stable position that no one can take away from them, and for delegates who completely own their roles, always having in mind respectfulness and professionalism. Also, as a reminder, the ideas you present shall be completely yours, remember you are the ones to seek a change for the world in the future.

Best regards, and welcome to MONUA XVI!

Danna Calvo  
Chair of the Presidential Council



## WELCOME LETTERS

# Presidential Council



Hello Delegates!!

My name is Sara Buitrago López, I am 18 years old, and I am a third-semester student of International Relations and Economics at the Universidad del Rosario. It is an honor to be your Dais of the Presidential Council in this edition of MONUA XVI.

This committee will challenge you to navigate one of the most complex and pressing geopolitical and economic issues facing our current international system: the recalibration of sanctions imposed on the Russian Federation, particularly regarding LNG restrictions, banking penalties, and worldwide tariff structures. This issue goes beyond economic concerns, as the use of these measures directly influences diplomatic stability and energy security around the world.

As your Dais, we highly value diplomatic dialogue, the active search for innovative solutions, and strategic thinking, creating an environment of high political tension where national interests and the fundamental principles of the United Nations converge. Our goal is to create an academic and dynamic environment where proposals are not only creative but also realistic and consistent with international dynamics. The Presidential Council needs delegates who can make far-reaching decisions that balance the global economy, political responsibility, and the protection of human rights.

We invite you to come to this space with new ideas, intellectual curiosity, and above all, confidence. Don't be afraid to challenge yourselves, embrace your ideas, and defend the role that you are representing. I hope this committee will be a place that pushes you to think critically, seek diplomatic alliances, and devise policies that reflect the complexity of our international system.

I am truly excited to work with you and to be part of the impact you can make as delegates, as the solutions you craft here will reflect the kind of leadership our global challenges demand.

Welcome to MONUA XVI!!

Sara Buitrago  
Chair of the Presidential Council

## Section

# Preamble

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**Regarding Electronic Devices:** Within the United Nations SGA, the use of electronic devices such as laptops, tablets, or iPads is permitted. Delegates may use these devices to gather information, edit documents in real time, and use MONUA Connect (MONUA's platform for messaging and other activities) during session days. The misuse of these devices, such as social media, video games, or other distractions, is strictly prohibited during committee meetings and will result in a warning to the delegate. Committee dais or other members of the academic staff will monitor the proper use of each device.

The use of cell phones during session times is strictly prohibited. If a delegate wishes to contact their sponsor, they must request permission from the chairperson via floor message, and the chairperson will arrange the call. In case of a personal situation, the chairperson may be notified, and an exception will be made.

**On the Use of Artificial Intelligence:** For the United Nations Deputy Under-Secretariat-General, the use of artificial intelligence is limited to the generation of images and videos. If spell-checking is performed using artificial intelligence, it must be reported to the dais before editing so that the initial version can be reviewed. The use of any artificial intelligence for generating text or speeches, or for research (during any session), is strictly prohibited and will result in a reprimand if detected. We believe that the responsible use of AI will enrich the debate and energize the committee; however, the preparation and soft skills of the delegates are fundamental pillars for the committee's academic development, and therefore we expect them not to rely on AI to demonstrate these skills. In particular, the research and proposals generated by artificial intelligence are evident.

## Section

# Introduction

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The Presidential Council is a high-level simulation body created by MONUA that brings together the highest political representatives of each member state of the United Nations. It is not a formally established UN organ; rather, it functions as MONUA's central coordination and decision-making body, designed to simulate the political environment in which heads of state and senior diplomatic representatives negotiate the most complex issues in the international system. Its decisions take the form of political directives, draft resolutions, and joint declarations, and are considered binding within the simulation insofar as they set the parameters within which all other MONUA committees must operate. The Presidential Council does not have enforcement powers beyond the model, but its resolutions should reflect the limits of international law, the foreign policy of each represented actor, and realistic economic and institutional constraints.

Within this framework, the Presidential Council is not only a space where leaders defend national interest, but also a collaborative environment where cooperation, dialogue, and collective necessity converge. The committee has the mandate to establish cooperation strategies that seek to protect and promote international stability, economic governance, and security. Delegates are expected to exercise diplomatic discipline: the political weight of this body demands that proposals be grounded in international law, responsive to the positions of the represented states, and cognizant of the economic consequences for third parties.

For this edition, the Presidential Council will center its debate on the international sanctions imposed on the Russian Federation, examining their impact on geopolitics, economic stability, and global security. The committee will operate in a dynamic environment where sanctions on Russia are defined, recalibrated, strengthened, conditioned, or eased, particularly those related to liquefied natural gas (LNG) restrictions, banking penalties, and large-scale trade tariffs, as financial pressures and energy vulnerabilities threaten to affect the entire international system.

Delegates are expected to analyze sanctions as instruments of statecraft, evaluate their effectiveness, and determine whether their consequences remain bound to the targeted state or extend across international borders. Resolutions should address enforcement mechanisms, humanitarian exemptions, coordination with third countries, energy compensation, financial monitoring, shadow fleet evasion, periodic review of sanctions, and the conditions under which existing measures could be modified or lifted.

## Section

# Definition of the Topic

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The term “recalibration of sanctions on Russia” refers to the deliberate modification of existing economic sanctions in order to adjust their scope, intensity, or design in response to changing geopolitical conditions and evasion strategies. Recalibration is not inherently synonymous with escalation: it may involve strengthening enforcement, filling gaps, coordinating efforts among allies, expanding the number of targeted entities, introducing targeted reductions, granting humanitarian exemptions, conditioning sanctions on specific political outcomes, or improving compliance mechanisms. The objective is to maximize the effectiveness of the sanctions regime while minimizing unintended consequences for third-party economies and civilian populations.

Liquefied natural gas (LNG) restrictions are a major component of this recalibration. Energy exports represent a central source of national revenue and geopolitical influence for Russia. Sanctioning governments target LNG through import bans, restrictions on investment, and limitations on technology and infrastructure cooperation, with the aim of reducing fiscal inflows and leverage derived from energy dependence. However, because energy markets are globally interconnected, such measures must be carefully calibrated: disruptions can produce price volatility and unanticipated economic effects for both the targeted state and the sanctioning countries, as well as for developing economies with limited capacity to absorb energy price shocks.

Banking penalties and financial restrictions constitute another crucial element. These regulations seek to limit access to international financial systems, increase transaction costs, and reduce liquidity. Asset freezing, restricting correspondent banking relationships, banning cross-border payments, and strengthening compliance protocols to prevent evasion are examples of financial sanctions. By restricting access to credit, foreign reserves, and international markets, banking penalties aim to undermine macroeconomic stability and limit the government’s capacity to finance strategic objectives. Financial isolation is considered one of the most effective tools of economic statecraft, but it also carries systemic risks for the global monetary order, particularly when it incentivizes the development of parallel financial architectures.

Finally, trade tariffs represent a trade-based mechanism of economic pressure. Unlike complete embargoes, tariffs increase the cost of imports from the targeted state, reducing export competitiveness while preserving a formal trade relationship. These measures aim to lower

export earnings and express political disapproval. Tariff recalibration provides flexibility: states can maintain some degree of economic contact while adjusting pressure in response to changing geopolitical conditions. It is essential that delegates distinguish between these three categories of measures when designing proposals, as each has a distinct legal basis, affected actor set, and potential for unintended consequences.

## ■ Classification of Sanctions: Primary, Secondary, and Countermeasures

The following table summarizes the three main categories of restrictive measures in the current regime. Delegates are encouraged to analyze which category best justifies each proposed measure and anticipate the legal and political challenges associated with each.

| Type                | Imposed by                                | Obligates                                                  | Legal basis                                                      | Main controversy                                                         |
|---------------------|-------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Primary sanctions   | Sanctioning state (e.g., U.S., EU)        | Nationals and entities of the sanctioning state            | IEEPA, EU Regulation 833/2014, UN Charter Art. 41                | Legality under WTO; trade diversion effects                              |
| Secondary sanctions | U.S. principally; increasingly EU-aligned | Third-country nationals and companies with U.S./EU nexus   | CAATSA (U.S. Congress, 2017) executive orders; OFAC designations | Extraterritoriality; violation of state sovereignty; WTO incompatibility |
| Countermeasures     | Injured states under ARSIWA               | Only the sanctioning state itself (inter-state obligation) | ARSIWA Arts 49-53 (International Law Commission, 2001)           | Proportionality; third-party effects; collective countermeasures debate  |

## Section

# Context

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## ■ a. Economic

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The wave of sanctions imposed on the Russian Federation represents one of the most significant and far-reaching economic coercion strategies in the post-Cold War era. The first sanctions were implemented following the annexation of Crimea in 2014 by the European Union and the United States, including asset freezes and restrictions on state banks' access to Western markets, limitations on exports in the energy sector, and embargoes on investment and trade with Crimea. These sanctions marked the beginning of a structured economic pressure system against Russia, but the turning point came in 2022 with the full-scale invasion of Ukraine.

The 2022 sanctions articulate a multidimensional system that simultaneously restricts the financial, energy, and technological channels of Russian industry. If the financial sector, the exclusion of major Russian economic entities from the SWIFT system and the freezing of approximately €300 billion in international reserves represent mechanisms for isolating Russia from the international financial system. The increase in oil prices and trade restrictions reinforce pressure on the energy sector, and restrictions on technology exports are designed to produce long- and medium-term effects on the country's productive capacity. Taken together, these measures constitute a regime of economic coercion with significant structural reach.

The energy sector is key to understanding the sanctions dynamics. Before 2022, approximately 40% of the natural gas consumed in Europe came from Russia, creating a structural dependency. According to the European Commission, by 2024 Russian oil exports to the EU had fallen to around 19%, reflecting the energy diversification policies implemented under the REPowerEU plan.

Quantitative models and econometric studies allow for an assessment of the cumulative impact. Bachmann et al. (Bachmann & others, 2022) estimated that a comprehensive trade embargo could reduce Russia's real GDP by more than 14% in the short and medium term relative to a no-sanctions scenario. Financial market research by Kholodilin and Netsunajev (Kholodilin & Netsunajev, 2020) shows that whenever sanctions are imposed or extended, exchange rate volatility and Russian stock index fluctuations increase significantly, reflecting a rise in perceived macroeconomic and financial risk.



Russia's response to the sanctions must also be considered. Despite the magnitude of the sanctions regime, the country's economy did not experience the immediate collapse initially projected: the actual GDP decline in 2022 was approximately 2–3%, the result of capital controls, increased public spending, the redirection of energy exports toward Asia, and import substitution measures. Analyses published by Russia in *Global Affairs* (Russia in *Global Affairs*, 2022) describe this as a “structural adaptation under sanctions”, a process characterized by trade diversion, temporary fiscal subsidies, and greater state intervention in strategic sectors. However, the cumulative effect of the sanctions regime has been progressive: by 2025, oil and gas revenues had dropped 23% of federal budget revenues, with revenues falling from \$146 billion in 2024 to \$111.2 billion in 2025.

The role of non-Western actors is central to any economic analysis. China and India have remained the primary buyers of sanctioned Russian oil, benefiting from heavily discounted supply. China has accelerated the development of CIPS (Cross-Border Interbank Payment System) and promoted yuan internationalization, partly in response to the use of SWIFT as a geopolitical tool. India, facing U.S. tariff pressure, has begun to reduce its purchases of Russian crude. Brazil, South Africa, Turkey, and Gulf states occupy strategically ambiguous positions: as energy buyers, BRICS partners, or potential financial intermediaries, their behavior directly affects the sanctions regime's efficacy. Several of these states have a structural interest in avoiding precedents for extraterritorial sanctions that could be applied against them in the future.

## ■ b. Political

Russia's political trajectory in the 21st century has been defined by a series of escalations that have progressively narrowed the space for cooperative multilateral engagement. The annexation of Crimea in 2014 represented the first major rupture: Russia seized the peninsula from Ukraine, citing the rise of pro-Russian sentiment in the region and its strategic military significance. Although the Crimean parliament voted to join the Russian Federation, this outcome was not recognized by the United Nations General Assembly (United Nations General Assembly, 2014) nor by the majority of member states, which regard the annexation as a violation of Ukrainian sovereignty and territorial integrity. The EU Council responded by restricting bilateral relationships with Russia and imposing targeted measures (Council of the European Union, 2014).

Russia's response to the 2014 sanctions demonstrated a capacity for economic adaptation that had been underestimated by Western analysts. The Russian government accelerated a process of de-dollarization, reduced its exposure to Western financial infrastructure, and developed the SPFS as a domestic alternative to SWIFT. While these measures cushioned the immediate impact of financial restrictions, they did not eliminate Russia's underlying financial vulnerabilities, as OFAC has noted that participation in SPFS carries its own sanctions risk signals and does not constitute a complete substitute for SWIFT connectivity (U.S. Department of the Treasury, OFAC, 2024).

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In the early hours of February 24, 2022, President Putin declared the beginning of a “special military operation” and launched a full-scale invasion of Ukraine. The international response was one of the broadest coalitions of economic pressure in post-Cold War history: the EU, U.S., G7, UK, Australia, Japan, and South Korea imposed sweeping financial, energy, and trade sanctions within weeks. Russia’s relationships with the majority of Western states deteriorated severely, and Putin declared a state of confrontation not only with the United States but with the broader Western coalition actively supporting Ukraine, including Germany, France, Italy, and the United Kingdom.

The political positioning of states outside the Western coalition requires careful analysis. China has consistently sought to frame the conflict as a product of NATO expansionism and U.S. interference, a narrative designed to blunt domestic criticism and consolidate Russia’s alignment with Beijing’s strategic interests (Wilson Center, 2022). However, the position of many states in the Global South is more nuanced: they do not necessarily endorse Russian conduct, but they reject the imposition of extraterritorial sanctions without Security Council authorization, object to double standards in Western responses to conflicts elsewhere, and are concerned about the direct economic harm that energy and commodity price spikes inflict on their populations. This distinction, between strategic alignment with Russia and principled resistance to coercive multilateralism, is essential for accurate political analysis in this committee.

## Section

# Topic's Development

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The international sanctions regime against the Russian Federation has undergone a continuous and accelerating process of recalibration since its inception in 2014. Rather than constituting a static set of punitive measures, these sanctions have evolved in direct response to Russia's adaptation strategies, leading the sanctioning states to recognize that isolated measures are insufficient to achieve their stated objectives. Understanding this evolution is essential to any discussion of how the current regime can be further adjusted to maximize effectiveness while minimizing unintended global consequences.

The three main axes of the sanctions regime, energy restrictions, financial sanctions, and trade tariffs, do not operate in isolation. Their interaction is what gives the regime its systemic character: energy sanctions reduce Russian export revenues, weakening the fiscal base; banking sanctions complicate payments for Russian exports and limit the government's capacity to repatriate earnings or access credit; tariffs raise the cost of goods originating in Russia and Belarus, reducing export competitiveness across sectors; and secondary sanctions apply pressure to third-country intermediaries who would otherwise sustain trade and financial flows that circumvent primary measures. Delegates should analyze proposed measures in terms of how they reinforce or undermine these systemic connections.

## ■ a. LNG and Energy Recalibration

One of the crucial examples of sanctions recalibration can be observed in the EU's progressive approach to Russian LNG. Initially, the EU avoided direct restrictions on Russian gas due to the continent's significant energy dependency: before 2022, approximately 40% of Europe's natural gas supply came from Russia. Early sanction packages deliberately excluded energy to prevent economic self-harm among member states.

This posture began to change with the 14th sanctions package (June 2024), which introduced targeted bans on LNG reloading services within EU territory, specifically for transshipment operations destined for third countries, and prohibited new investments in Russian LNG projects under construction, including restrictions on services and new investments in Russian LNG projects (Council of the European Union, 2024). These measures constrained Russia's capacity to use EU infrastructure as a transit hub without yet cutting off direct imports.

The most decisive escalation came with the 19th sanctions package (October 2025), which introduced a total ban on Russian LNG imports into the EU and extended a full transaction ban to major Russian energy companies Rosneft and Gazprom Neft (Council of the European Union, 2025). This marked a structural commitment: the EU was no longer adjusting incentives at the margin but accepting significant short-term economic costs in pursuit of long-term energy independence. This package also targeted intermediaries in third countries that purchase, refine, or transport Russian crude oil, marking a significant shift in strategy; it is now recognized that effective sanctions must reach beyond Russia itself to the international networks that enable evasion.

## ■ b. Banking and Financial Recalibration

When sanctions were first imposed in 2022, several Russian banks were disconnected from SWIFT. However, not all Russian banks were included, and Russia had already been building SPFS as a domestic alternative. Recognizing this gap, the 18th sanctions package (July 2025) replaced the SWIFT-based measure with a broader transaction ban, expanding the number of targeted Russian financial institutions from 23 to 45, meaning that conducting any transaction with these institutions became outright prohibited rather than merely technically restricted (European Commission, 2025; White and Case, 2025).

The persistence of SPFS as an evasion channel requires careful analysis. According to International Finance Bank LTD (IFX Payments / International Finance Bank LTD, 2026), multiple international banking agencies have adapted to the SPFS system, including Gazprombank Switzerland, the Bank of China, and AO Subsidiary Bank Alfa-Bank in Kazakhstan. This reduces, but does not eliminate, Russia's financial vulnerability. OFAC has explicitly warned that joining SPFS constitutes a sanctions risk signal, and that participation in this system may expose foreign financial institutions to U.S. secondary sanctions exposure (U.S. Department of the Treasury, OFAC, 2024). The idea that SPFS renders Russia immune to financial isolation is therefore analytically inaccurate and should be avoided in committee debate.

## ■ c. Trade Tariffs and Secondary Measures

Beyond energy and finance, the recalibration of tariff-based measures has introduced an additional lever of economic pressure. The EU has implemented a 35% tariff on imports of certain goods originating in Russia and Belarus, alongside restrictions on Russian metals. These measures aim to reduce Russia's export earnings across sectors while preserving a formal trade relationship.

The Trump administration has introduced a distinct dynamic of conditionality. President Trump publicly stated that he was considering large-scale banking sanctions and tariffs contingent on a ceasefire and definitive peace agreement in Ukraine (The Hill, 2025). Rather than treating sanctions purely as punishment, this approach uses them as diplomatic leverage.

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Trump also threatened secondary tariffs of up to 100% on countries purchasing Russian oil, expanding the sanctions framework beyond bilateral pressure on Russia itself. India, facing this pressure, has begun to reduce its purchases of Russian crude.

## Section

# Key Trade-offs

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The topic of sanctions recalibration does not have a single correct answer. Delegates are expected to engage honestly with the following structural tensions:

- Pressure on Russia vs. global energy inflation: tighter energy sanctions increase costs for European consumers and developing economies dependent on global LNG markets.
- Economic punishment vs. humanitarian harm: comprehensive financial and trade restrictions affect civilian populations and restrict access to goods, medicines, and financial services.
- Western unity vs. global legitimacy: the sanctioning coalition is large but not universal. Unilateral and plurilateral measures lack the legal authority of Security Council resolutions and are contested by a majority of UN member states.
- Effectiveness of sanctions vs. monetary fragmentation: escalating financial sanctions accelerate the development of alternative payment systems (CIPS, SPFS) and may permanently fragment the global financial architecture.
- Energy security vs. climate transition: forced energy diversification may accelerate renewable deployment in Europe, but energy scarcity drives some developing states toward more carbon-intensive alternatives.
- Secondary sanctions as leverage vs. sovereignty violation: extraterritorial measures pressure third-country actors effectively but are legally contested and generate diplomatic backlash.



## Section

# Chronology of Key Events

The following timeline provides a reference for committee debate. Delegates are encouraged to consider how each escalation stage shaped Russia's adaptation strategies and the coalition's subsequent responses.

| Date              | Event                                                                                                                                                                     |
|-------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| February 2014     | Russia annexes Crimea. EU and U.S. impose first asset freezes and access restrictions on state banks.                                                                     |
| 2014–2021         | Gradual expansion of sectoral sanctions; Russia begins SPFS development; partial de-dollarization of reserves.                                                            |
| February 24, 2022 | Full-scale invasion of Ukraine. EU, U.S., G7, Australia, Japan, and South Korea impose sweeping financial, energy, and trade sanctions.                                   |
| March 2022        | SWIFT disconnection of major Russian banks (not all). Freeze of €300 billion in Russian Central Bank reserves.                                                            |
| 2022–2023         | REPowerEU plan launched. The EU accelerates energy diversification. Coal import ban enters into force.                                                                    |
| June 2024         | 14th EU sanctions package: targeted ban on LNG reloading in EU territory for transshipment to third countries; restrictions on new LNG project investments.               |
| July 2025         | 18th EU sanctions package: SWIFT replaced by broader transaction ban; targeted Russian banks expanded from 23 to 45 (European Commission).                                |
| October 2025      | 19th EU sanctions package: full ban on Russian LNG imports into the EU; full transaction ban extended to Rosneft and Gazprom Neft; third-country intermediaries targeted. |
| 2025–2026         | REPowerEU 2026 implementation milestones. Russian oil/gas revenues fall to 23% of the federal budget. India begins reducing purchases under U.S. tariff pressure.         |

## Section

# Sanctions Measures

The following table provides a structured overview of the main sanctions measures currently in force, their stated objectives, their key risks, and the actors they affect most directly.

| Measure                                              | Objective                                                                            | Risk                                                                                | Affected actors                                                             |
|------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LNG import ban (19th package)                        | Eliminate EU dependency on Russian gas, reduce Russian energy revenues               | Supply shortfalls; price spikes in global LNG markets; harm to developing economies | EU member states, global LNG buyers, Russia (Novatek, Gazprom)              |
| Transaction ban on 45 Russian banks                  | Sever Russian access to international financial flows                                | Evasion via SPFS, CIPS, correspondent banking in third countries                    | Russian banking sector, international counterparties, sanctioning states    |
| 35% tariff on Russian/Belarusian goods               | Reduce export earnings; increase cost of Russian-origin goods                        | WTO compatibility challenges; trade diversion to third markets                      | EU importers, Russian exporters, Belarusian economy                         |
| Reserve freeze (€300 billion)                        | Deny Russia access to foreign reserves; limit capacity to stabilize ruble            | Precedent risk for non-Western reserve holders; IMF systemic concerns               | Russian Central Bank, Western financial institutions, global reserve system |
| Secondary tariffs (up to 100%) on Russian oil buyers | Pressure third-country buyers (India, China, Turkey) to reduce Russian oil purchases | Diplomatic tensions; inflationary pressure; acceleration of de-dollarization        | India, China, Turkey, Gulf states, global oil markets                       |
| G7 oil price cap (\$60/barrel)                       | Allow some Russian oil trade while capping revenues                                  | Shadow fleet evasion; declining enforcement; market circumvention                   | G7, Russia, price cap coalition, shadow fleet operators                     |

## Section

# Main Deterrences for the Topic

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The effectiveness of recalibrating Russia's sanctions faces several structural and geopolitical obstacles. Financial sanctions are designed to restrain Russia's capacity to fund strategic objectives, including restrictions on correspondent banking and sovereign debt. However, as multiple international banking agencies have adapted to the SPFS system, reducing, though not eliminating, the costs of financial isolation, the lack of universal participation in the sanctions coalition creates opportunities for evasion. This is not a complete insulation from financial pressure: OFAC has explicitly noted that SPFS participation is a sanctions risk signal, and Russia's financial system remains exposed to dollar-denominated transactions and correspondent banking relationships (U.S. Department of the Treasury, OFAC, 2024).

There are also significant disagreements regarding LNG restrictions. Although many countries support pressuring Russia in principle, concerns persist about supply shortages, price spikes, and the adequacy of alternative supply arrangements. The IEA's Global Gas Security Review (International Energy Agency, 2024) documented the fragility of global gas balances and limited LNG supply growth and geopolitical-driven market price spikes. The European Commission has therefore emphasized a graduated approach to reducing dependency on Russian energy (European Commission, 2026), rather than an immediate comprehensive ban, a strategic posture that the 19th package has now substantially accelerated.

The shadow fleet represents a particularly acute enforcement challenge. Russian oil is increasingly transported by a network of uninsured, opaque-ownership vessels that avoid Western port calls and bypass G7 price cap enforcement mechanisms. This fleet, shared with Iranian and other sanctioned actors, effectively creates a parallel logistics infrastructure for sanctioned commodities (Middle East Institute, 2025; VoxUkraine, 2025). Effective sanctions recalibration must account for shadow fleet interdiction, including port access restrictions, insurance market pressure, and satellite tracking of vessel movements.

Finally, political solidarity among sanctioning states is not unconditional. Price rises in energy and commodities lead to diverging interests among coalition members, with some preferring limited enforcement, exemptions, or partial disengagement rather than an escalatory path. The European Commission has continuously emphasized the need for a united front, but individual member state interests, particularly those more exposed to energy price volatility, create internal tension within the coalition.

## Section

# Legal Framework

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The debate over the recalibration of sanctions cannot proceed without a solid understanding of their legal basis. Economic sanctions operate at the intersection of public international law, United Nations law, and the domestic legal frameworks of the sanctioning states.

## ■ United Nations Charter

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Article 41 of Chapter VII of the UN Charter establishes the foundational legal basis for coercive non-military measures: the Security Council may decide what measures not involving the use of armed force are to be employed, including the total or partial interruption of economic relations and the severance of diplomatic relations (United Nations, 1945). In the case of Russia, the application of Article 41 has been structurally precluded by Russia's veto power as a permanent Security Council member. This means that the current sanctions are not multilateral measures authorized by the UN, but rather unilateral or plurilateral measures adopted by states or coalitions of states in the exercise of their sovereignty.

This distinction carries fundamental legal consequences: while Security Council sanctions are binding on all UN member states, unilateral or plurilateral sanctions are binding only on the states that adopt them. Third countries have no legal obligation to comply with them, though they may face political or economic pressure to do so, a pressure that, when institutionalized through secondary sanctions, itself generates significant legal controversy.

## ■ Countermeasures Under ARSIWA (International Law Commission, 2001)

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The ILC's Articles on State Responsibility for Internationally Wrongful Acts (International Law Commission, 2001) codify the concept of countermeasures: temporary suspensions of international obligations toward the responsible state, aimed at inducing compliance. Many sanctions against Russia can be understood as countermeasures in response to the invasion of Ukraine, an act contrary to the prohibition on the use of force in Article 2(4) of the UN Charter. However, ARSIWA does not function as an automatic authorization for any measure a state chooses to adopt. The doctrine imposes significant substantive and procedural constraints:

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- a. Purpose (Art. 49): Countermeasures may only aim to induce compliance, not to punish. A punitive rationale, however politically understandable, falls outside the legal doctrine.
  - b. Limitations (Art. 50): Countermeasures may not violate peremptory norms of international law (*jus cogens*), including fundamental humanitarian law obligations.
  - c. Proportionality (Art. 51): Countermeasures must be proportional to the injury suffered, accounting for the gravity of the wrongful act. This is the criterion that generates the most debate: to what extent can extending sanctions to third-party intermediaries in India, Turkey, or China be justified as proportionate to the original act of aggression?
  - d. Prior demand (Art. 52): The injured state must formally call on the responsible state to comply with its obligations before adopting countermeasures.
  - e. Reversibility (Art. 53): Countermeasures must be temporary and must cease when the responsible state fulfills its obligations.

There is also an unresolved doctrinal debate about whether states not directly injured by the wrongful act, so-called “third states” acting in the collective interest, may legally invoke ARSIWA countermeasures. This debate is directly relevant to the legitimacy of the broader sanctions coalition.

## ■ WTO Law and the National Security Exception

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Trade sanctions and tariffs imposed on Russia may conflict with WTO obligations, particularly the most-favored-nation (MFN) principle under the GATT, which prohibits discriminatory tariff treatment against a WTO member without legal justification. Article XXI of the GATT allows WTO members to adopt otherwise incompatible measures when necessary to protect essential security interests. For decades, it was assumed that each state was the sole judge of what constituted a security threat. However, the *Russia, Measures Concerning Traffic in Transit* case (WTO Dispute Settlement Panel, 2019) changed this: the WTO panel established that, while states have broad discretion, such determinations are not entirely autonomous and may be subject to external review. Any proposal relying on the security exception must be able to demonstrate a genuine and verifiable security threat, not merely a political motivation framed in security language (WTO Dispute Settlement Panel, 2019).

## ■ Secondary Sanctions and Extraterritoriality

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Secondary sanctions are measures that threaten consequences for companies and individuals in third countries that transact with designated Russian entities, even if those companies have no U.S. or EU nexus. The Countering America's Adversaries Through Sanctions Act (CAATSA) (U.S. Congress, 2017) and Trump's threatened 100% tariffs on buyers of Russian oil exemplify this instrument. The extraterritorial application of secondary sanctions has drawn sustained

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criticism from India, China, and several European countries, which view it as a violation of state sovereignty and international economic law. From a legal perspective, the legality of secondary sanctions remains actively contested in academic and diplomatic discourse and represents one of the major fault lines in contemporary global economic governance.

## Section

# Thematic Approaches to the Analysis

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The debate can be arranged around three core themes or methods that enable the analysis to be structured from complementary perspectives because the Presidential Council is dealing with a single subject with several facets. During the discussions, delegates will need to negotiate the intersection of these approaches, which are connected rather than mutually exclusive.

## ■ Approach 1: Security of global energy

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Since energy is the main source of income for the Russian government and the biggest vulnerability for the European nations enforcing the sanctions, it is at the center of the discussion around sanctions against Russia. It is impossible to evaluate any recalibration of energy sanctions without taking the security of the world's supply into account.

Before 2022, Russia was the world's biggest supplier of fertilizers made from natural gas and supplied around 17% of the world's natural gas and 12% of its oil. Although they are a useful tool for applying pressure, energy sanctions have unintended consequences that affect developing economies outside of the conflict, global energy markets, and food supply systems.

Delegates are prompted by the energy security strategy to consider how to raise pressure on Russian energy revenues without creating shortages or price fluctuations that disproportionately harm vulnerable economies. What forms of compensation or technical support should be included with energy sanctions to guarantee aid from the Global South? Does the G7 price cap need to be modified in order to accommodate the 2025-2026 market conditions, or is it an adequate tool?

This strategy also takes into account the energy transition aspect: sanctions may have a favorable side impact on international climate pledges to the extent that they hasten European energy diversification. However, several developing nations contend that shortages brought on by sanctions compel them to turn to more polluting sources, putting security and environmental goals at odds.



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## ■ Approach 2: International financial stability and fragmentation of the monetary system

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Financial sanctions, specifically the Russian Central Bank's reserves being frozen and Russian institutions being barred from the SWIFT system, have spurred a deeper discussion about the structure of the global financial system and its vulnerabilities.

While not endorsing Russia's conduct, the use of Western financial infrastructure (SWIFT, the dollar as a reserve currency, and the interbank payment system) as a foreign policy tool has alarmed nations that worry about being targeted by similar penalties in the future. In reaction to what it sees as the «weaponization» of the Western financial system, China, in particular, has hastened the development of the CIPS (Cross-Border Interbank Payment System) and encouraged the internationalization of the yuan as an alternative to the dollar.

This approach forces delegates to think about how financial penalties would affect the global monetary system in the long run. Global economic stability, the handling of financial crises, and the capacity of multilateral organizations (World Bank, IMF) to carry out their missions would all be significantly impacted by a fragmented system with a dollar/euro bloc and a yuan/ruble/SPFS bloc.

This strategy's primary concerns are: How the financial sanctions regime continue to be a useful tool without permanently shattering the global monetary system? Is there a point at which financial sanctions become more detrimental to the global order than they are beneficial in terms of applying pressure to Russia? Should organizations like the IMF or the Bank for the International Settlements oversee the development of multilateral systems for evaluating financial sanctions?

## ■ Approach 3: International law, legitimacy, and global governance

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The third strategy concentrates on the debate's institutional and legal aspects: when do unilateral or plurilateral sanctions become coercive tactics that undermine multilateral standards, and under what circumstances are they acceptable tools of the international order?

This strategy is especially pertinent to nations in the Global South that, whilst denouncing the invasion of Ukraine, are worried about creating precedents that would allow Western nations to impose worldwide sanctions without the Security Council's approval. These countries' main claim is that the sovereign equality of states might be undermined by the deployment of a system of unilateral penalties with chosen political criteria in the absence of global mechanisms.

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From a different angle, the nations spearheading the sanctions regime contend that additional avenues for collective actions are necessary due to Russia's chronic blockage of the Security Council through its veto power. Outside of the Security Council, collective action has been based on the precedent of «united action for peace» (United Nations General Assembly, 1950)

This strategy encourages the investigation of novel ideas. Is it possible to create multilateral systems for evaluating and keeping an eye on economic sanctions? When the Security Council is at a standstill, should the General Assembly create standards and protocols to justify plurilateral sanctions? How can it be made sure that sanctions are reasonable, revocable, and subject to regular evaluations of the humanitarian effects?

The Presidential Council's deliberations are defined by the interaction of these three strategies: legal governance, financial stability, and energy security. The most well-known delegates will be those who can form alliances amongst actors with somewhat different interests, articulate viewpoints that logically incorporate all three dimensions, and suggest solutions that recognize the trade-offs between them.

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Section

# Previous Documents

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Delegates must submit a **position paper** and an **opening speech**. Both documents must be sent to the Dais email address by the deadline indicated below:

■ **Submission deadline: August 11 before midnight (11:59 p.m.)**

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## Section

# Qarmas

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1. How much have sanctions affected Russia's strategic decision-making, and to what extent do they encourage long-term resistance and adaptation rather than compliance?
2. How can sanctions be recalibrated to increase pressure on critical sectors, energy, banking, and technology, while reducing systemic risks to international markets and third-party economies?
3. Are sanctioning states and the targeted state bearing asymmetric costs? To what extent are energy dependency and inflationary pressures disproportionately affecting the sanctioning coalition itself?
4. How far do escalating sanctions contribute to geopolitical fragmentation and the consolidation of alternative financial and economic systems (CIPS, SPFS, yuan internationalization)?
5. In comparative terms, how effective are financial sanctions, reserve freezes, banking restrictions, relative to energy restrictions and trade tariffs in constraining Russian state capacity?
6. Without unambiguous enforcement mechanisms and universal participation, can sanctions remain a legitimate and sustainable instrument of international governance?
7. To what extent can secondary sanctions be justified under international law, and how should the committee address the sovereignty concerns of states targeted by extraterritorial measures?
8. How should the committee address the shadow fleet problem? What enforcement mechanisms, port access restrictions, insurance market measures, satellite monitoring, are feasible and proportionate?
9. What humanitarian exemptions should be incorporated into sanctions design, and what oversight mechanisms should guarantee that exemptions are not used as evasion channels?

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10. Under what conditions, political, legal, or military, should sanctions be modified, suspended, or lifted? What benchmarks for compliance should guide a future sanctions review process?
  11. How should the committee balance the interests of Global South states that bear indirect economic costs from sanctions-driven energy and commodity price increases without having endorsed the sanctioned conduct?

## Section

# Glossary

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- **Sanctions (economic sanctions):** Restrictive measures adopted by governments or international organizations to change a state's behavior without resorting to military force.
- **Recalibration of sanctions:** The process of modifying the scope, intensity, or design of existing sanctions, which may involve escalation, reduction, conditioning, or improved enforcement.
- **Primary sanctions:** Measures that prohibit nationals and entities of the sanctioning state from engaging with designated targets.
- **Secondary sanctions:** Extraterritorial measures that impose consequences on third-country companies or individuals conducting transactions with designated entities, regardless of any direct connection to the sanctioning state.
- **Countermeasures:** Temporary suspensions of international obligations by an injured state toward a responsible state, governed by ARSIWA Articles 49–53. Subject to requirements of purpose, proportionality, prior demand, and reversibility.
- **Extraterritoriality:** The application of a state's domestic law to conduct or persons outside its territory. Legally contested when applied to third-country nationals without a genuine nexus to the sanctioning state.
- **Liquefied Natural Gas (LNG):** Natural gas chilled to liquid state for storage and transport. A central axis of the sanctions debate given Russia's role as a leading global LNG supplier.
- **SWIFT:** Society for Worldwide Interbank Financial Telecommunication. A global financial messaging network; exclusion restricts a country's access to international payment flows.
- **SPFS (System for Transfer of Financial Messages):** Russia's domestic alternative to SWIFT, developed to reduce financial isolation. Participation by foreign institutions constitutes a sanctions risk flag under OFAC guidance.

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- **CIPS (Cross-Border Interbank Payment System):** China's international payment system, increasingly promoted as an alternative to SWIFT and a channel for yuan-denominated transactions.
  - **Price cap:** A ceiling set by the G7 and EU on the price at which Russian oil may be sold to countries using Western shipping and insurance services. Designed to allow some Russian oil trade while capping revenues.
  - **Shadow fleet:** A network of vessels, typically opaque-ownership and uninsured, used to transport sanctioned Russian oil while evading Western port access controls and price cap enforcement.
  - **Correspondent banking:** An arrangement under which one bank holds deposits with another bank to facilitate cross-border payments. Restriction of correspondent banking is a central financial sanctions mechanism.
  - **Reserve freeze:** Immobilization of sovereign assets held in foreign jurisdictions. The freeze of approximately €300 billion in Russian Central Bank reserves in 2022 is the largest application of this measure in history.
  - **Sanctions evasion:** The use of intermediaries, front companies, alternative payment systems, or shadow logistics to circumvent sanctions restrictions. A primary target of recalibration efforts.
  - **Humanitarian exemptions:** Provisions within a sanctions regime that permit transactions for food, medicine, and humanitarian aid to the civilian population of the targeted state.
  - **National security exception:** The WTO Article XXI provision allowing members to adopt otherwise WTO-incompatible trade measures when necessary to protect essential security interests. Subject to external review since WT/DS512 (WTO Dispute Settlement Panel, 2019).
  - **De-dollarization:** The deliberate reduction of dependence on the U.S. dollar in trade, reserves, and financial transactions. Accelerated by Russia, China, and BRICS partners in response to the use of dollar infrastructure as a sanctions tool.
  - **Asset freeze:** A restriction on the access or use of financial assets held by individuals, companies, or governments in foreign jurisdictions.
  - **Trade tariffs:** Taxes levied on imported goods to raise their price and reduce their competitiveness. Applied as a trade-based mechanism of economic pressure within the sanctions regime.

## Section

# Assignments

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1. United States
2. Russian Federation
3. China
4. Germany
5. France
6. Iran
7. Israel
8. India
9. Ukraine
10. Italy
11. Turkey
12. United Kingdom
13. Saudi Arabia
14. Japan
15. Brazil
16. Qatar
17. South Korea
18. Australia
19. South Africa
20. Australia
21. South Africa
22. Pakistan
23. Indonesia
24. Mexico
25. Egypt
26. Nigeria
27. Kazakhstan
28. United Arab Emirates
29. Hungary
30. Switzerland
31. Netherlands
32. Belarus



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